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Child Development and Family Guidance

SIMPLE FINE MOTOR ACTIVITIES TO BUILD THE HAND SKILLS

REQUIRED FOR BUTTONING

(The following skills are to be followed sequentially, once a child has mastered the skill you can move to the next skill)

1. **Button practice with containers:** A clean plastic container is needed for this activity. Cut a slot in the cover. Get your child to place large and small disc like objects such as coins, buttons, game coins using their pincer grasp into the rigid plastic slots. Increase the challenge by shifting the orientation of the slot from time to time. This activity helps to develop the pincer grasp.



2. **Pushing buttons into playdough:** Hold coins or buttons on the edge and press them into play dough so they are standing on their edge. This activity helps to develop the finger strength needed to push the button into buttonhole.





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3. **Button Practice with Container Lids:** This involves using only the container lid. The child needs to push large and small buttons through the slot in the container lid, while holding the lid in his other hand and then catching the button from the other side with his hand. This activity helps to develop the bilateral use of hands needed for the buttoning task.



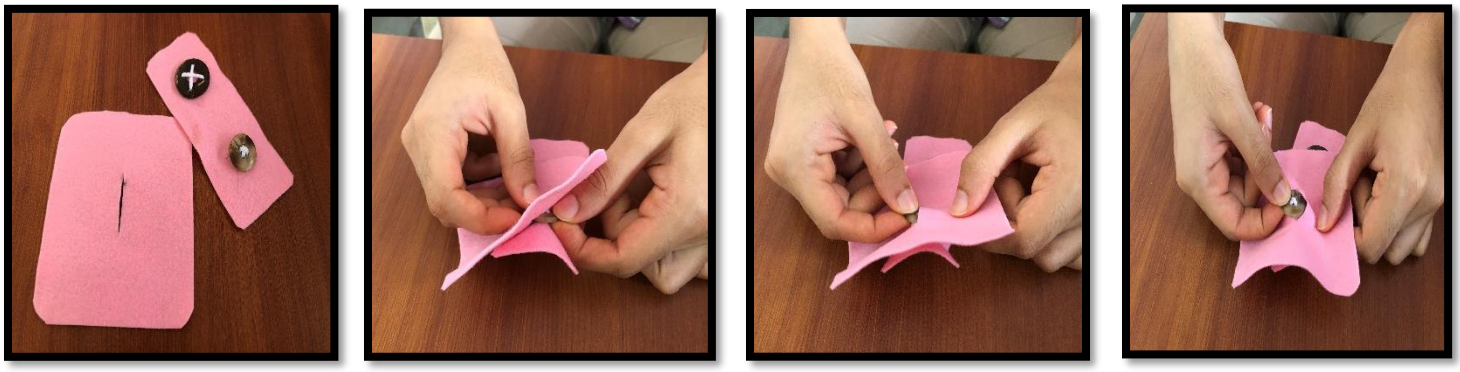


4. **Buttoning Practice with Fabric:** We continue to develop the coordinated use of both hands with this activity. Give the child a small piece of cloth, or felt, with one hole or slot. Have them put a few buttons through the one piece of fabric. The child starts by holding the cloth with his non-dominant hand. Using his dominant hand, he starts to slide the button through the slot. He shifts his hands so that he can continue holding the cloth and is able to pull the button out of the slot with his other hand.




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5. **Practice with Clothing:** After laying the fine motor foundational skill with the above-mentioned activities, the final button practice step is to start practicing with regular clothing such as a shirt. Begin practice with large sized buttons, gradually moving on to smaller sized buttons. Now your child is ready to slide the button through a fabric slot, while it is attached to a second piece of fabric.



With these simple activities and regular practice, your child will learn to button successfully!